

Is Malta first in the EU for reported pollution?

A media claim, tested against Eurostat survey data

THE CLAIM

“35% of people in Malta reported exposure to pollution in 2023 — the highest share in the EU.”

Amphora Media, 2026 Election Guidebook: The Environment, 12 May 2026

Source not named in the guidebook; the figures match Eurostat's EU-SILC survey.

The survey asks about pollution, grime or other environmental problems: what people report.

VERDICT

SUPPORTED

*Accurate figures,
in Eurostat's own words.*

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

34.7%

The figure is right

Eurostat EU-SILC, 2023: people reporting pollution, grime or other environmental problems.

12.2%

Nearly three times the EU

EU-27 average in 2023. The ratio is 2.84.

1st

Highest in the EU

Greece is second at 20.5%. Malta was first in all 17 survey years since 2005.

41 → 27 → 35%

Fell, then rose again

41.4% in 2011, 26.5% in 2017, 34.7% in 2023: the highest since 2014.

Reported

Eurostat's own wording

Eurostat calls this people "reporting exposure to pollution". It is what households report, not measured air quality.

FAIR TO SAY

Amphora's note that higher earners reported more problems matches 2023 (35.6% against 30.1%), but the "higher" group is everyone above the poverty line (83% of people), and the gap has reversed in 6 of 17 years.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ The source Amphora used (not named).

☐ Measured exposure data to set beside this survey.

☐ The 2026 survey results, when published.